

FIELD LIBRARY / ACTION CHECKLIST

Water purification

FIELD SKILLS / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Use safe bottled water when available. For microbial risk, bring clear water to a rolling boil for 1 minute, or 3 minutes above 6,500 feet, and cool before use. Water contaminated with fuel, chemicals or radioactive material cannot be made safe by boiling or ordinary disinfection.

Do now.

- ☐ **Check the source**
01 Avoid floodwater or sources suspected of toxic contamination; find an approved alternative.
- ☐ **Clarify cloudy water**
02 Let sediment settle or strain through a clean cloth before treatment; this alone does not disinfect it.
- ☐ **Boil for germs**
03 Use the appropriate time and cool safely in a clean container.
- ☐ **If boiling is unavailable**
04 Use a treatment product as labeled and official guidance for your water source; filters have different capabilities.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Choose the least contaminated available source and establish whether the problem is microbial or chemical. If the source may contain fuel, industrial chemicals or radioactive material, find another source; a camping filter or boiling is not a universal solution.

Watch for.

Clear water can still contain germs. Ordinary filters may not remove viruses or chemicals.

People & practical needs.

Keep untreated and treated water in different labeled containers. Use clean utensils and teach each person how safe water is dispensed

Next decision.

Store treated water in clean covered containers and prevent recontamination.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

SOURCES / SCOPE / LIMITS

Source-linked civilian guidance, not independent clinical or specialist certification. U.S. references; emergency numbers and services differ. Training and product instructions remain essential.

Water purification · official guidance

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/guides/water-purification/>